

"Entry-level netbooks needed improvement on cost; UbiSurfer is our answer"

Q: When and why did Datawind decide to enter the mobile Internet netbook market?

A: We launched our first mobile netbook in the UK in September 2009. After the success of our PocketSurfer devices, we wanted to extend our free-usage business model to other platforms, and felt that entry-level netbooks needed an improvement, especially with respect to costs. Thus, we decided to enter the mobile Internet netbook market.

Q: What are your top products? How many models are available for UbiSurfer?

A: Our top products are the UbiSurfer and Pocket Surfer series. Currently we have two models of UbiSurfer - WinCE and the Linux version.

Q: What makes UbiSurfer your top product and a great value proposition for netbook buyers?

A: UbiSurfer is our top product for its 'ubiquitous surfing' capability that offers the Internet on the go, with an integrated SIM card slot and a cellular modem. Further, the UbiSurfer spec sheet is rather impressive. It has an 18 cm (7-inch) TFT, wide-screen display, a resolution of 800x480 pixels (WGA), 128 MB RAM, 1 GB flash memory, and is supported by an ARM 11 processor. It features an embedded cellular modem (both GPRS and CDMA 1xRTT versions are available) along with wireless LAN Wi-Fi IEEE 802.11 b/g and 10BaseT Ethernet interface. It has a lithium polymer battery that gives a back up of 3-4 hours. (There are a number of options for extended usage, including additional replacement batteries and car-chargers.) It also has two USB ports, a Push-Push SD card socket (maximum capacity 32 GB) and an Ethernet port. Its aggressive pricing at Rs 7,999, a reasonably priced package of Rs 999 after the completion of one year of free Internet, and anywhere Internet capability is sure to make it a favourite pick among netbook buyers too. 50 GB of expandable online storage comes bundled with the device; if more storage is required, it can be expanded, at a higher price. There are no restrictions on the type of data that can be stored—office documents, videos, pictures, etc.

Q: Whom will one have to approach to renew Internet connections after a year? Will users face vendor lock-in wherein they will be dependent on Datawind for bandwidth, which in other words means to operate the device, since it is an Internet device?

A: Customers can pay the network operator directly, or put in their own SIM if they wish—but in the case of the latter, they'll be dependent on the rates charged by the operator. In order to take advantage of our free-usage and Rs 999 unlimited usage, the customer needs to utilise our compression service and the SIM pre-embedded in the device.

Q: What type of cellular modem is built in? Would this modem support 3G services—for example, BSNL/MTNL, and other operators who will now start rolling out 3G services?

A: There are both GPRS and CDMA 1xRTT versions available for the built-in modem. Since the 3G coverage in India is negligible, we will wait until next year to introduce a 3G product. Because of the higher modem cost, it will be priced accordingly. We don't recommend that consumers pay double or triple the cost of the product to get 3G today, when there's no real network yet.

Q: Is there any software or way to place a voice call (as one would from a mobile phone) via the UbiSurfer?

A: The UbiSurfer is intended as an entry-level computer and mobile surfing device. Voice calling has not been a focus. Urgent communications can be handled by Web-based SMS, instant-messaging and e-mail.



other entry-level netbooks," says Tuli, during an interaction over Skype. He adds: "We have tied up with Tata Teleservices to be our mobile service provider with no bandwidth limitations or upper limit, but the free usage and unlimited usage is restricted to our compression/acceleration servers. We also operate on the GSM and the CDMA platforms, which gives UbiSurfer the advantage of working with all carriers across India and offering uninterrupted services nationwide."

But, why Linux?

Datawind decided to develop the Linux-based UbiSurfer after an internal survey among UK-based retail partners revealed a substantial demand for a Linux-OS mobile Internet netbook, due to the cost advantage. "We were not concerned about perceptions about usability as we felt that open source was just beginning to climb the popularity peak in the developing markets, thus apprehensions were bound to exist. If we could

provide the user uninterrupted Web access at a cheap price, the Linux-based UbiSurfer was sure to be a winner," says a confident Tuli. The Debian-based OS is a modified version created by Datawind, since this was the most appropriate choice for the processor specifications.

Passing on the advantage to the user

Cost was the most obvious benefit resulting from using the embedded Linux OS on the UbiSurfer—and that was passed on to the users. Apart from that, a Linux OS ensured perfect performance, adaptability and robustness of the device. "UbiSurfer not only helped our consumers save on licensing fees, but also on margins added by manufacturers and channels to bring the device to the customer. It also gave them a stable work environment, and a secure software platform," says Tuli.

Further, Datawind has built an exciting set of open source applications for UbiSurfer users. "We have contributed to the